



TEAM AIRTEL WITH
CAPTAIN MITTAL

“ WHAT MAKES ME REALLY PROUD IS THAT WE have the best telecom team in the world. ”

SUNIL MITTAL, *Chairman & MD, Bharti Airtel*

Rs 36,962 cr

Revenue earned in
2008-09

24 per cent

Bharti Airtel's share
of total wireless
telephone market

32.4 mn

Number of subscribers
added between April
2008 and March 2009

the question away with a smile and a gentle “it’s all frozen now”.

Of course, times are inopportune for a career switch. The telecom market is getting competitive, with more players coming in. Almost every analyst’s report following the Q4 results has placed the sector on watch and predicted that it is likely to underperform. Mittal agrees there will be pressure and tariffs may come down. But he also believes that when all else is equal “the differentiator will be quality which can be offered only when you have scale”. Also, unlike existing players who have it all in place, the new entrants have to invest to expand and hope to earn.

For now, though, the Airtel team is focussed on the next revolution, 3G-HSPA. Even as the Government was dilly-dallying about terms and timing

of the 3G auction, Mittal’s team has done the full dress rehearsal. “We can press the buttons tomorrow and in 180 days we will be operational,” he says with a confident grin. Once again the objective is market domination. Contrary to conventional wisdom he believes cost will not be an inhibitor and 3G will move and grow the market. Tariffs, he points out, are around \$50 a month abroad and could be as low as \$20 in India. 3G HSPA is essentially data flying on jet fuel. From video downloads to live TV and online gaming, 3G services will offer mobile broadband and transform the market. With investments in value-added services Airtel is already among the top players and earns nearly 10 per cent of its revenues in value-added services.

For Mittal, though, the excitement is not so much in videos, music or m-news. “I see the potential of total transformation from health to education to social services if one can use 3G services to deliver governance.” Even as his team and the others celebrate the achievement, Mittal is working on his next dream. Aligning 3G with e-G, or e-governance. ■



“ MITTAL IS A TERRIFIC COMPETITOR because he has the ability to make decisive moves at defining moments. ”

ASIM GHOSH, *Former MD, Vodafone*